

Chilcott

In his introduction to translating Bashō's *Oku no Hosomichi*, Tim Chilcott challenges assumptions about what you truly need in order to translate literature. Instead of treating proficiency in the source-language as a necessity like Estienne Dolet, he looks at whether it is "possible to translate from a language of which one has little or no knowledge" (p. i). He notes himself that it could be impossible, listing barriers such as not having an individual voice, or needing to use imitation because of lack of understanding and wondering whether "all these barriers can be surmounted" (p. ii).

His approach to this project treats it as an experiment, noting the massive structural and terminology differences between English and Japanese. To address this, he looks at different English translations together, finding the "lowest common denominators (whether part of speech or syntactic ordering)" and also "the differences in tone and register between them" (p. iv).

Where Dolet required complete comprehension of the source language and rejected word-for-word translation, Chilcott instead relies on "Makoto Ueda's word-for-word versions" (p. vi) as a resource to give signals about relationships between words, although he considers them as part of the process rather than the end. Rather than aiming to be an independent translator, he works upon the shoulders of those who wrote before him. Chilcott strictly retains the 5-7-5 syllable count of haiku and intentionally avoids capitalization and most punctuation to retain the "suggestiveness and ambiguity" (p. viii), saying "*haiku* begin before the first syllable is uttered, just as they sound long after the seventeenth syllable is heard" (p. viii).

Overall, Chilcott demonstrates that translating an unknown language, even one far from your known languages, is not impossible. In fact, by using resources and deliberate intention, all the barriers he proposed can be surmounted, making the translator part of the process more explicitly, putting together other translations and scholarship like a conductor, hoping for himself to be "a partially hearing man who prepared himself to conduct Stravinsky by discovering, at least, how to read a musical score" (p. ix).